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Prompt 3

Climate Catastrophe and the Non-Identity Problem

In his 1984 book *Reasons and Persons,* Derek Parfit proposes a problem, the Non-Identity Problem, arguing for the impossibility of any moral obligation to the wellbeing of future persons. The problem arises from four key premises which evaluate to an invalid argument. This problem can be extended to a justification of taking no action against climate change despite the negative effects such policy would have on future generations. I seek to reconstruct Parfit's argument through the premises that support it, and further present an objection against the assumptions and definitions smuggled in by Parfit's language. First, I will make explicit the implicit assumptions required for Parfit's Non-Identity Problem and define the key terms relevant to the problem. Next, I will examine the premises comprising the problem, reconstructing the problem and assessing its validity. Finally, I will offer objections to the soundness of the argument and provide possible responses to these objections.

Parfit begins by establishing a definition of harm that will be used in his argument. He claims that an action is harmful to another person if that person would have been better off had the action not counterfactually been committed. For instance, Peter harms Quinn when Peter punches Quinn in the nose because Quinn would have been better off in the counterfactual case of not being punched in the nose. Furthermore, Parfit assumes details surrounding the problem

that mold it into the unyielding problem that it is. The first of these is the principle of time-space-dependency of identity, which asserts that one's identity and existence is unique to the exact moment and situation they were conceived. This principle is based on the biological understanding of fertilization and a reductionist view of personal identity. Furthermore, Parfit supposes that existence is better than nonexistence. This assumption must be granted, or else the problem falls apart for reasons that will soon be apparent. Finally, for the specific case of a moral obligation to future generations to prevent climate change, we must suppose that the wellbeing of future persons is the only moral reason for preventing a climate change, and that these future persons will nonetheless have lives worth living regardless of the catastrophic environment, a principle I call hedonic adaptation.

The line of reasoning in the Non-Identity Problem is predicated on two of the aforementioned principles: the definition of harm and the time-space-dependency of identity. The latter is particularly salient, as it voids the existence of counterfactual persons to compare wellbeing between. Parfit's Non-Identity Problem, then, is as follows:

1) *In the case of a climate catastrophe, the present generation wronged the future generation.*
2) *If the present generation wronged the future generation, the way the present generation wronged the future generation was by harming it.*
3) *The only way the present generation could have harmed the future generation is by making the future generation worse off than it otherwise would have been.*
4) *The present generation did not make the future generation worse off than it otherwise would have been.*

The problem that arises from this argument is that Premises 2, 3, and 4 cannot be the case along with Premise 1. If the present generation did not make the future generation worse off than it otherwise would have been, then the present generation could not have wronged the future generation by the definition of harm. Parfit emphasizes that the existence of a counterfactual world where climate catastrophe is avoided necessarily has different material conditions from the catastrophic world, making the two possible future generations inherently composed of sets of entirely different persons. As stated above, there are no counterfactual persons to compare wellbeing to. Thus, no one is harmed, especially because the existence of the catastrophic generation makes them better off than their otherwise nonexistence. This detail highlights the necessity of accepting the assumption that existence is better than nonexistence.

The first solution I offer to this issue is a solution by symmetry. In both possible worlds, a generation of persons is deemed unharmed by the policies of a past generation. Just as the argument claimed there to be no reason to prevent climate change, symmetrically there is no reason to allow it, either. If this variable cancels out on both sides of the policy decision equation, then there must be a new variable introduced to tip the decision to one side or another. This is where additional moral values can contribute to a decision in favor of preventing climate change. Parfit may respond to this argument that this solution can only work in situations of perfect equality in population sizes between the generations, otherwise whichever population size is larger will inevitably overshadow the smaller one, even if the persons contained in that population have lives barely worth living. Parfit calls this the Repugnant Conclusion. However, I claim that Parfit boxes himself into this consequentialist conclusion by assuming some underlying pleasure or happiness measure into the undefined shell of ‘wellbeing.’ One such objection to this is the principle of hedonic adaptation: Humans have a psychological tendency to

return to a base state of pleasure or contentment regardless of the material conditions they exist in. Both the ultra-wealthy and poverty-stricken can experience the same wide berth of emotions – the wealthy are not infinitely riding dopamine highs and the impoverished are not in a constant state of depression. This suggests an underlying utilitarian bias of Parfit's that conditions a life worth living on the quality of surrounding material conditions. The vast majority of humans that ever existed lived lives worth living in material conditions worse than the contemporary.

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